reflecting on the silver platter. She planned to leave a trace of herself in the reflection, just as Claesz and the other artists did. Then a shudder ran through her as she remembered the skulls from those paintings, how they sat like ticking clocks in the corners, reminding the viewer that time was short. Was that what she'd been feeling all day—a sign that something would happen to her and Léa tonight? No, she was thinking too much. One step after another and she'd soon be there.

When Rose reached the oak tree that marked the end of the tunnel, she put the wheelbarrows down and felt around in the grass for the metal door. Finding it, she knocked three times and waited.

The metal hatch creaked open. It took Léa a few pushes to loosen it enough to break the seal of weeds that had grown up around it.

"Léa?" Rose whispered.

"I'm here. Hold on, I'll bring up the first crate."

Rose placed the wheelbarrows side by side. Once Léa reappeared, she took the crate and put it in the wheelbarrow, and it went on like that until both wheelbarrows were full of demijohns.

"Perhaps we should bring the rest of the crates out and stack them on the grass?" Léa suggested.

"Yes. Hand them to me."

Once they had all the crates out, Léa left the hatch open. There was no handle on the outside, so closing it would mean she couldn't open it when they returned.

"Let's go." The sisters wheeled the barrels through the grass to reach the jetty. Virginie had said the man would be there at two in the morning, and just as they came upon the jetty, the church bell rang out twice. The *péniche* was waiting. They could see a man standing on the grass, smoking a pipe.

"Where's Édouard?" he said, his voice fraught. "I agreed to meet Édouard, not two women."

"He couldn't come," Léa said. "He sent us instead."

The man threw his cigarette to the ground and stubbed it out. "I don't like last-minute changes. Let's get this over with." He helped them unload the wheelbarrows, counting the crates as he stacked them on the boat. "Where's the rest?"

"Around the corner," Léa said.

"What? Sitting ducks get shot."